

Morocco: Election will shift coalition balance

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A reshuffle of power is likely among the outgoing tripartite governing coalition. The three parties in Morocco's outgoing governing coalition—the RNI,|||||||

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Election likely to reshape ruling coalition as Islamists recover ground

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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The Party of Authenticity and Modernity (PAM) will likely win most seats in the 23 September parliamentary election, boosted by popular politician Fouzi Lekjaa joining the party in July, while the National Rally of Independents (RNI) will bear the brunt of falling support for the outgoing government.

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Public discontent and pro-Palestinian sentiment will help the Islamist opposition Justice and Development Party (PJD) rebound from its crushing 2021 defeat and probably enter coalition talks, but the former ruling party is unlikely to lead the next government.

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Policy space will remain limited for the incoming government, as the 2030 World Cup infrastructure spending and social commitments constrain the budget, while the government will remain secondary to the palace on setting foreign policy.

A reshuffle of power is likely among the outgoing tripartite governing coalition. The three parties in Morocco's outgoing governing coalition—the RNI, PAM, and Istiqlal—will probably retain a large share of parliamentary seats, but the 23 September election is likely to reallocate power among them. Opposition parties are set to make gains amid growing socioeconomic grievances, but probably only enough to enter coalition talks, not to lead a new government.

Lekjaa’s popularity boosts PAM’s odds of winning the most seats. Lekjaa, who is a household name in Moroccan politics and sports, joined PAM in late July, adding momentum to the party's campaign. He is the Minister Delegate for Budget in Prime Minister Aziz Akhannouch's cabinet, and has presided over the Royal Moroccan Football Federation since 2014. He has led Moroccan soccer to a string of achievements, including winning the bid to co-host the 2030 World Cup and building a globally successful national team.

Speculation has surged over Lekjaa's odds of leading Morocco's next government. In September, he called the speculation premature and denied any intention of becoming prime minister, citing winning the election as his priority. Still, PAM remains best positioned to win the most seats, which would put Lekjaa in contention to lead the government.

The RNI will likely lose its leadership position atop the coalition. As the face of the outgoing government, the RNI will bear the brunt of declining support tied to socioeconomic grievances, especially youth unemployment and inadequate healthcare and education. Those grievances, along with perceived overspending on 2030 World Cup infrastructure, triggered 2025 protests calling for the government's resignation (see: Regime remains stable despite youth protests over World Cup spending , 6 October 2025). The July Ceuta incident, in which at least 140 Moroccans died after an estimated 60,000–80,000 migrants, predominantly young Moroccan men, breached the border and surged into the Spanish enclave, deepened frustrations with the government (see: Mass border breach will likely give the far-right a one-off boost , 31 July 2026).

Akhannouch's decision to step down from the RNI leadership, effectively ruling out a new term as prime minister, is an attempt to decouple the party from his personal unpopularity ahead of the vote. His successor, Mohamed Chaouki, lacks Akhannouch's name recognition and patronage networks and is unlikely to move the needle in the RNI's favor.

PJD will likely rebound, though it is unlikely to lead the next government. The Islamist opposition PJD, which led Morocco's first two governments after the 2011 protests, will likely gain seats after suffering a crushing defeat in 2021, when it lost 112 of the 125 seats it had won in 2016. The party has been highly critical of the government, capitalizing on the 2025 protests, the Ceuta incident, and rising pro-Palestinian sentiment following the war in Gaza, positioning itself as an opponent of closer ties with Israel (see: Ruling coalition likely to lose seats in elections amid declining support , 13 February 2026).

The return of Abdelilah Benkirane, the veteran politician and former prime minister, to lead the party after its 2021 defeat will also boost the PJD's odds. The party will likely fall short of the seats needed to lead a new government, given the collapse of support for it between 2016 and 2021, but it will probably emerge as one of the four largest parties in the new parliament and enter into coalition talks.

Policy space will remain limited for the next government. World Cup–related infrastructure investment, estimated at about \$20 billion, will constrain public spending through 2030. The new government will also find it difficult to unwind the 18% increase in healthcare and education spending in the 2026 budget, enacted in response to the 2025 protests. Electoral pledges such as PAM's five-year, 350-billion-dirham (\$37 billion) program, which is largely driven by social spending and does not call for tax hikes, are therefore unlikely to fully materialize if Rabat commits to fiscal consolidation.

Moroccan foreign policy will also remain stable under the new government, as the palace sets this agenda rather than the government. Strong ties with Europe will continue to drive Morocco's economy despite rising tensions with Spain (highlighted by the Ceuta incident); European countries remain Morocco's top trade partner and top source of FDI, remittances, and tourism. Ties with Israel will also deepen following a September agreement, reached days before the election, to upgrade bilateral diplomatic missions to full embassies and exchange ambassadors. Tensions with Algeria will endure, particularly as Rabat's autonomy plan for Western Sahara gains more international support.

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